



Visualize your home theatre setup before you start browsing. It will be a great help later on

goes completely dark. Look for traces of residual light along the panel's edges (backlight bleed), and if you find any cross that TV off your shortlist.

3. If you notice a visible difference of brightness between two competing TV models, and if the sales guy's giving you "gyaan" about why one TV is brighter than another, investigate the situation further. Ask for the TV's remote and play around with its brightness and contrast levels.
4. Don't just observe the TV's picture from directly in front, move sideways to the right and left to check for the panel's viewing angles. Ideally, you shouldn't notice colour shifts at all or a bare minimum at best from different vantage points.

Ask

1. Always check the services and support network of the brand of TV you're purchasing, in case the TV develops faults post-purchase. Is the nearest service centre in your suburb or a city several hundred kilometres away? The answer can greatly influence your ultimate decision.
2. Warranty periods for most TV sets are for 1 year. But ask the guy if the brand you're interested in offers extended warranty. If it's a fraction of the TV's sales price, go for extended cover.



Sorting through cameras and choosing the right one can be an arduous task, especially if you don't know what you're looking for. The plethora of cameras to choose from and their myriad features – some not even related to photography – can be daunting for the novice. We'll try to sort out the mess for you and point you in the right direction.

Research

1. Research is very important, not necessarily on what camera is good, but more importantly to check out what features are available and what you need. GPS and geo-tagging might be fluff for some, or must have features for others. Try to understand your needs first and then start looking.
2. Megapixels (MP) don't matter. Don't get taken in by marketing mumbo-jumbo touting more megapixels as a bonus. Even 6 MP cameras, but with large sensors, will beat a small sensor 12 MP camera any day. If you've shortlisted some cameras, check their sensor sizes (in mm) if you're picky about image

quality. If you have the time, it might be a good idea to take a print-out or to try and remember various sensor size specifications as many manufacturers use different naming conventions.

3. Things like startup times and digital zoom don't really matter. Look for more important things such as stereo microphones (for video), multiple scene modes (if you don't want the hassle of manual setup), battery life, etc.

Observe

1. A digital camera is primarily for taking images and videos and that is what you must do with the camera. Take as many pictures as you can, portraits, macro, with flash and without. If you're not comfortable with the myriad of settings available, just put the camera in auto mode and try it out. When reviewing the images, make sure you review them at a 100 per cent zoom factor rather than looking at the overall image on the LCD. You will notice details (or lack thereof) at such a zoom level and will be able to take a better decision regarding image quality. Some cameras for example, use very aggressive noise-cancellation algorithms, resulting in images that look fine zoomed-out, but look like blotches of colour once you zoom in to 100 per cent.
2. Ideally, use your own memory card or transfer the images from the store's memory card to a laptop or tablet/ phone that you have with you. Stores won't allow you to do that, but it doesn't hurt to try.
3. While shooting video, try to zoom in and out (if the camera supports it) and



Are the buttons well placed?